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Ethics is a crucial aspect of any research endeavour. Research ethics is concerned with the treatment of people involved in the research. The researcher should always exhibit fairness, honesty and integrity.

Most Universities including ours require that researchers to explicitly state the ethical aspects of the research, provide a plan for ethical behaviour and obtain ethical clearance before the research may begin. DUT has the pg2a proposal template that contains a concise ethical clearance application. This is approved at Department, Faculty and Institutional level committees.

Plagiarism is not tolerated in research. Most universities impose severe penalties and sentences on those practicing plagiarism. Researchers must avoid predatory publishers.

1. Rights of participants

Participants are those people directly involved or affected by the research. These may include:

- participants being interviewed, questioned or observed (sometimes these are entire organizations and not just individuals);
- other researchers in the research project;
- academic community who read, review and cite the research;
- those that are directly impacted by the result of the research or its creations.

Participants should not be used simply for the researchers own end. They should not be manipulated, deceived, blackmailed or coerced into participation (for example consider the unethical software developer manager conducting research in his/her place of employment).

Oates (2006) highlights the following participant rights:

- The right not to participate
- The right to withdraw
- The right to give informed consent (i.e. their consent is given only when they are fully aware of their involvement and the nature of the research)
- The right to anonymity
- The right to confidentiality (NDA signed with a participating company)

2. Ethical behaviour of the researcher

Good researchers strive to ensure that they uphold and become custodians of sound ethical behaviour. The reputation of the researcher and the affiliate institution could be severely tarnished if research practice is otherwise.

Oates (2006) suggest the following practices:

- *Intrusion*: the researcher must be mindful of the type of data being collected. For example, asking the respondent about salary. Only necessary questions should be included and the researcher must be certain that the information that they are looking for is available and can be collected.
- *Integrity*: the data being collected must be accurately reported and not manipulated or falsified to fit the research. Further, data security and backup is the responsibility of the researcher.
- *Feedback*: participants must be given a full debriefing and access to results post research. This will allow them to benefit from the research. The researcher should consider how the research findings will be used.
- *Adhere to professional bodies code of conduct*: there are several professional bodies in IT (for example, ACM and IEEE) and each provide guidelines for professional conduct.
- *Reviewing*: maintain confidentiality of the content of the research being reviewed. Complete the review timeously. Provide eloquent criticisms and praise for the work.

The researcher is responsible for ethical data analysis and publication. Lapan and Quartaroli (2009) stress ethical violation via four common *mistakes*:

- *Fabrication of data*: includes making adjustments to data or filling in missing data.
- *Eliminating an outlier*: an *outlier* is a participant whose responses were very far or drastically different from the rest of the sample. This outlier may influence the results and lead to incorrect conclusions about the population. The researcher may eliminate the outlier but this must be stated in the publication.
- *Exploitation of data*: occurs when researchers make undue claims or overemphasis the significance of a finding.

3. Plagiarism

Plagiarism is the act of copying the work of others and passing it off as the researcher's own. Plagiarism also includes the act of copying the work of others without correct referencing to acknowledge the original authors.

Many universities including ours, have plagiarism policies. If found guilty, the university will hold disciplinary hearings for the researcher. Plagiarism in any assessment will result in a zero mark.

There are numerous software tools to assist in identifying plagiarism:

- Turnitin,
- Unicheck,
- Plagscan,
- Grammarly,
- Plagiarism,
- Plagtracker,

- Dupli Checker,
- Copyleaks,
- PaperRater,
- Plagiarisma,
- Plagium,
- Quetext,
- Viper

These are popular cloud based tools with features for identifying the plagiarized source and generating a concise report. Some are available for free.

4. Publications (predatory versus ISI and DHET)

Predatory publishing is a business model that exploits researchers by charging them publication fees for publishing in a very poor quality journal. Predatory journals often do not check the quality and legitimacy, lack a credible board of reviewers, do not have an editing service and publish poor quality research. Hence, there are no funding awards nor credits for publishing in a predatory journal. New scholars including students, are especially at risk of falling for predatory publishing.

Anderson (2017) stress that predatory journals engage in unfair and deceptive practices in the following ways:

- Falsely claim rigorous peer review.
- Claim individuals as editors when those individuals never agreed to become editors.
- Send solicitations to potential authors on behalf of other academics, without permission from those academics.
- Give their journals a nearly identical name as another respected journal.
- Fail to disclose publication fees until after authors submit articles, and demand payment to withdraw the article.
- Misrepresent the Impact Factor of their journals.
- Falsely claim that their journals are included in academic indexes such as, the ISI.
- Falsely claim that respected individuals will participate in conferences to increase attendance

Institutions and University libraries maintain a list of accredited publishers. Students and researchers must consult these lists before committing to publication.

In contrast, DHET and ISI accredited publishers maintain high quality and standards in academic publications. Researchers often receive credit and acclaim from publishing in these ranked journals. Institutions and University libraries maintain a list of DHET and ISI accredited publishers. These should be consulted for committing to a publisher.

Tutorial

List 3 negativities for a researcher should they publish in a predatory journal.

Reference list

Anderson, R. 2017. Federal Trade Commission and National Institutes of Health take action against predatory publishing practices. Available from:

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Oates, B. J. 2006. Researching information systems and computing. London. Sage.